

Qroo Paul's Spanish Master Course

Lesson 28 Summary

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This lesson goes beyond just memorizing colors. You'll learn how to use color words correctly as adjectives in Spanish—including agreement in gender and number, tricky exceptions like *naranja* and *café*, and how to describe light and dark shades. These subtle rules are often overlooked but make a big difference in speaking naturally and correctly.

1. Colors Are Adjectives

Colors in Spanish function as adjectives. That means:

- They usually come **after** the noun (unlike English).
- They **must agree** with the noun in **gender** and **number**, unless they're invariable.

Examples:

- *La casa roja* = The red house
 - *Las casas rojas* = The red houses
 - *El coche azul* = The blue car
 - *Los coches azules* = The blue cars
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2. Types of Color Adjectives

Type 1 – Fully Variable

These change for **gender** and **number**.

- Example: *rojo, blanca, amarillos, moradas*

Type 2 – Only Number Agreement

These adjectives change **only for number**, not gender.

- Example: *azul, verde, gris*

Type 3 – Invariable

These adjectives **don't change** at all. They're often borrowed from nouns or are compound colors.

- Example: *naranja, púrpura, café, color ladrillo*
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3. Using “Ser” vs “Estar” with Colors

- Use **ser** for permanent traits like the color of an object.
 - *La camisa es roja.*
 - Use **estar** for location or something temporary.
 - *La planta verde está en la cocina.*
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4. Light and Dark Colors

Use:

- **claro** for “light”
- **oscuro** for “dark”

These follow the color they describe and are **invariable**—they don't change to match the noun.

Examples:

- *verde claro* = light green
 - *azul oscuro* = dark blue
 - *Los zapatos verde oscuro*
 - *La casa es azul oscuro*
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5. Using “color + [color]”

To skip gender and number agreement altogether, use the “**color**” construction. It's always safe and grammatically correct:

- *zapatos color café* = brown shoes
- *camisa color salmón* = salmon-colored shirt
- *casa color ladrillo* = brick-colored house

6. A Note About Brown

The word **brown** is one of the trickiest to use in Spanish because there's **no single word that works in every context**. Usage depends on **region** and **context**:

- **Marrón** – common in Spain and Argentina, often used for shoes, eyes, objects
- **Café** – widely used in Latin America for most things that are brown
- **Castaño** – used for hair or sometimes eyes
- **Pardo** – more limited usage, often in set expressions like *oso pardo* (brown bear)

When in doubt, “**color café**” is a safe construction in most Latin American countries.

7. Color Reference List (Base Forms Only)

Here's a simple list of the color words introduced in the lesson. These are the base forms (masculine singular) you'll see in dictionaries or word lists. Once you know the pattern, you'll be able to adjust them as needed in context:

rojo – red
azul – blue
verde – green
amarillo – yellow
negro – black
blanco – white
gris – gray
naranja – orange (*invariable*)
anaranjado – orange (*variant that follows regular adjective rules*)
morado – purple
púrpura – purple (*usually invariable*)
violeta – purple (*usually invariable*)
marrón – brown
café – brown (*often invariable, especially in Latin America*)
castaño – brown (*commonly for hair or eyes*)
pardo – brown (*used in specific contexts like animals*)
claro – light (used after a color, e.g., *verde claro*)
oscuro – dark (used after a color, e.g., *azul oscuro*)

Well, that's it for this lesson. Hasta luego.